

COMPARATIVE DESIGN AUDIT

Two Websites, One Sacred Design Language

A visual aesthetic and UI/UX comparison of rothershrine.jesspete.shop and st-joseph.jesspete.shop - two parish sites built on one shared token system - evaluated from full codebase review and live browser evidence, with severity-classified findings and WCAG contrast verification.

Rother Shrine · St Joseph's Church Bukit Timah

Design Audit · 29 August 2026

EVIDENCE-BACKED · CONFIDENCE-LABELED · Z.AI

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1. Executive Summary

This report evaluates and compares the visual aesthetic and UI/UX design of two live websites: **Rother Shrine** (rothershrine.jesspete.shop), a pilgrimage site for the National Shrine of Blessed Stanley Rother in Oklahoma City, and **St Joseph's Church Bukit Timah** (st-joseph.jesspete.shop), a parish site for Singapore's second-oldest Catholic parish. The evaluation draws on two independent evidence streams: a full examination of both code repositories (React 19 + Vite 7 + Tailwind CSS 4 single-page applications) and live inspection of the deployed sites at desktop (1440 x 900) and mobile (375 x 812) viewports using an instrumented headless browser. Every claim in this report is tagged with a confidence level - Verified, Reasoned, or Assumed - and the verification ledger in Chapter 2 records exactly what was checked and how.

The single most consequential finding of the audit is a lineage fact: **st-joseph-bt is a direct content-port of rothershrine-v2**. The two codebases ship an identical 24-color shrine-* design-token system, the same Fraunces / Source Sans 3 typography program, the same component primitives (Container, Reveal, Accordion, SafeImage, Button), and the same ornamental vocabulary of woven-textile dividers, film-grain overlays, and self-drawing gold rules. This is documented in the ported repository itself: tokens are, in its own words, unchanged from the rothershrine line. The practical consequence is that the comparison is not a contest between two design systems but between two executions of one design system - the differences live in imagery, hero composition, motion choreography, and detail polish rather than in foundational choices.

On execution, both sites are unusually strong for their class: disciplined token usage with zero arbitrary hex values, WCAG AAA contrast intent, 44px touch targets, reduced-motion support, and hand-drawn emblem SVGs. However, both ship the same systemic defect family: **Fraunces headings on dark maroon surfaces inherit the global maroon-700 heading color and become nearly invisible** - measured at 1.19:1 to 1.39:1 contrast on Rother's home hero and quote band, and 1.26:1 on St Joseph's serve band, against a WCAG AA floor of 4.5:1. St Joseph's has fixed its home hero (cream headline, 17.5:1) while Rother has not. Balanced across eight evidence-weighted dimensions, St Joseph's edges ahead overall (8.8 vs 8.6 on a 10-point scale) on motion design and contrast remediation, while Rother leads on navigation depth, drawer accessibility engineering, and identity fixtures such as a favicon.

Severity	Count	Finding IDs	Headline
Critical	1	F-01	Rother home hero headline at 1.19-1.39:1 contrast - primary message illegible
High	2	F-02, F-03	Dark-band headings illegible on Rother quote band and St Joseph's serve band
Medium	3	F-04, F-05, F-06	Shared cascade root cause; JS-dependent content reveal; missing drawer focus trap
Low	2	F-07, F-08	Missing favicon; no automated axe-core accessibility gate
Informational	3	F-09, F-10, F-11	Threshold duplication; single-file bundle weight; deploy-drift risk

Table 1 - Findings summary by severity (details and evidence in Chapter 6).

Findings are classified using the audit severity taxonomy: Critical (blocks release), High (incorrect behavior in common paths), Medium (edge-case or resilience issues), Low (polish and consistency), Informational (observations and future considerations). Counts reflect Chapter 6 and are ordered by severity there.

2. Scope, Method & Verification Ledger

The audit covered four surfaces per site. First, the complete codebases were cloned from GitHub (nordeim/rothershrine-v2 and nordeim/st-joseph-bt) and examined for design tokens, typography, color application, layout systems, component inventories, motion definitions, responsive strategy, accessibility affordances, and documented design intent in README, CLAUDE.md, AGENTS.md and docs/ files. Second, each live site was loaded in a headless Chromium session at 1440 x 900 and 375 x 812, with screenshots of the hero, mid-page sections, footer, navigation drawers, and interior pages. Third, computed styles (font family, size, weight, and color of key headings; background colors of section bands) were extracted directly from the rendered DOM via `getComputedStyle` rather than inferred from source. Fourth, WCAG 2.x contrast ratios were computed mathematically from those extracted color values.

Confidence labeling follows a strict contract. **Verified** means the behavior was executed and directly observed in this environment - for example, the 72px Fraunces headline color on the live Rother hero was read back as `rgb(85, 25, 26)`. **Reasoned** means the claim follows from code inspection or the project's own audit documents but was not independently reproduced at runtime - for example, the missing focus trap in St Joseph's mobile drawer. **Assumed** claims are stated as assumptions; none appear in the findings register. Where the deployed build could differ from repository HEAD, the live-rendered evidence takes precedence, and drift risk is flagged (F-11).

Three limitations bound the scope. No performance profiling (Lighthouse, network traces, Core Web Vitals) was run; bundle observations come from build configuration and documentation, not measurement.

No usability testing with human participants was conducted - interaction quality is assessed against established heuristics (WCAG 2.2, WAI-APG patterns, touch-target guidance) rather than user data. Finally, the audit reflectives a single snapshot in time (29 August 2026); both repositories carry active remediation ledgers dated within the previous two days, so scores may shift as fixes land. None of these limitations weakens the contrast findings, which are computed from live rendered values.

What was checked	How	Result	Confidence
Design tokens, fonts, components, docs (both repos)	Full repo clone + file-level inspection	Identical shrine-* token block; port lineage confirmed	Verified
Live desktop rendering	Headless Chromium, 1440 x 900, screenshots	Both sites render as designed; no console errors observed	Verified
Live mobile rendering + drawers	Headless Chromium, 375 x 812, drawer open/close	Full-screen drawers work; Escape closes; scroll locked	Verified
Hero h1 computed color (Rother)	getComputedStyle on live DOM	rgb(85,25,26) maroon on dark hero - defect reproduced	Verified
Hero h1 computed color (St Joseph's)	getComputedStyle on live DOM	rgb(250,246,236) cream - fixed on hero	Verified
Dark-band heading colors (both)	getComputedStyle + section-band background match	maroon-700 on maroon-900 band, both sites	Verified
WCAG contrast ratios	Relative-luminance computation from extracted colors	1.19-1.39:1 (R), 1.26:1 (S) vs 4.5:1 AA floor	Verified
Drawer focus trap (St Joseph's)	Repo audit doc I-6 + code reading; Escape tested live	Trap and role=dialog absent; Escape works	Reasoned
Reduced-motion handling	CSS inspection, both repos	Global kill-switch + targeted overrides in both	Verified
Performance metrics	Not run in this environment	Out of scope; bundle ~376 kB (~110 kB gzip) from docs	Unverifiable here

Table 2 - Verification ledger: what was checked, how, and result confidence.

3. Shared Foundation: One Design System, Two Sites

St Joseph's Bukit Timah was ported from rothershrine-v2, and the port was disciplined about what it inherited. The docs/porting.md ledger in the st-joseph-bt repository maps every change - identity, routing, data, imagery, footer, 404 copy - while AGENTS.md states plainly that the design tokens are unchanged from the rothershrine line and that only the imagery and copy they frame is now Bukit Timah. Verification against the cloned sources confirms this: the @theme blocks in src/index.css of both projects define byte-identical token sets, and both ship the same 45-file-scale src/ tree with the same component primitive names. For the evaluator this is a gift: it removes foundation quality as a comparison variable and isolates execution craft.

The shared foundation is genuinely distinctive. The palette is a 24-step liturgical ramp - cream #faf6ec and parchment #f2e9d6 fields, an eight-step maroon ramp from #fbf0ee to #200a0a, gold accents #f8ecd2 to #a67a2e, with pine and terracotta support roles - and both codebases forbid arbitrary hex values outright. Typography pairs Fraunces, a variable optical-size serif, for display against Source Sans 3 for body, with a signature eyebrow micro-label system (11px uppercase, 0.22-0.35em tracking) and text-wrap balance on all display headings. Motion is transform/opacity-only on a shared cubic-bezier(0.22, 1, 0.36, 1) ease-out-quint curve, gated by a global prefers-reduced-motion kill-switch in both codebases. Ornament is architectural rather than decorative: repeating-linear-gradient woven dividers quoting Guatemalan and liturgical textiles, an SVG feTurbulence film-grain layer at 3.5% opacity, and self-drawing gold rules under section headings.

The engineering contract underneath the aesthetics is also shared. Both apps are single-file Vite builds (the entire app inlines into one index.html, roughly 376 kB, about 110 kB gzipped) running on HashRouter, which forces unusual but careful adaptations: skip links that must not rewrite the URL hash, hash-aware scroll restoration with an 80ms delay, and back-to-top behavior that bypasses router navigation. Both repositories document accessibility as doctrinal - WCAG AAA intent, documented contrast pairs, keyboard-complete accordion and dropdown patterns - and both carry dated design-review and remediation ledgers showing the design system is actively maintained rather than frozen. In short, the baseline from which the two sites diverge is a coherent, opinionated, and well-documented design language.

Shared primitive	Specification (identical in both repos)	Evidence
Color tokens	24 shrine-* colors: cream/parchment fields, maroon 50-950 ramp, gold 100-600, pine, terracotta	src/index.css:3-39, both repos
Type program	Fraunces variable serif display + Source Sans 3 body; 11px uppercase eyebrows at 0.22-0.35em tracking	index.html font links; SectionHeading, PageHero
Motion curve	cubic-bezier(0.22, 1, 0.36, 1); transform/opacity only; global reduced-motion kill-switch	src/index.css:68-80, both repos
Ornaments	divider-weave textile stripes; bg-grain feTurbulence at 3.5% opacity multiply; gold-rule draw animation	src/index.css:83-152, both repos
Layout primitive	Container = mx-auto max-w-7xl px-5 sm:px-8; banded cream/parchment section rhythm	ui/Container.tsx, both repos
HashRouter adaptations	Hash-safe skip link, double-hash scroll restore (80ms), imperative back-to-top	SkipLink.tsx, Layout.tsx, both repos
Contrast doctrine	Documented AAA pairs: ink/cream ~13-14.7:1, cream/maroon-900 ~13:1, gold-300/maroon-900 ~7:1	SKILL.md sections 8 / 8.1, both repos

Table 3 - Shared design primitives verified identical in both repositories.

4. Visual Aesthetic Comparison

Because the token layer is shared, aesthetic differences surface only where the two teams made independent composition choices: hero architecture, photographic art direction, motion choreography, and identity detailing. This chapter walks those differences dimension by dimension, with live-rendered evidence.

4.1 Color application and materiality

Both sites paint with the same 24-color ramp, but the brushwork differs. Rother builds its home page as a sequence of deep maroon-950 theatrical surfaces - a full-viewport hero and a later quote band - alternating with cream and parchment editorial fields, and it leans hardest on the materiality utilities: the adobe-texture radial wash and the multiply-blended film grain sit over nearly every maroon surface, giving dark regions an earthy, plaster-like depth. St Joseph's distributes the same darks more sparingly; its home page reserves maroon-900 for a single serve band, runs a longer cream/parchment banded middle, and overlaps a cream quick-facts card across the hero's bottom edge, which lightens the first viewport and pushes schedule information above the fold. The trade is atmosphere against information: Rother's opening viewport is more cinematic, St Joseph's is more immediately practical. Both applications are token-pure; live background sampling confirmed the deployed sites match the declared hex values exactly (page background rgb(250, 246, 236) on both).

4.2 Typography

The type program is identical in raw material and diverges in voice. Both load the same Google Fonts families and both scale display type to 72px at desktop - but Rother sets its hero in Fraunces italic medium at a 0.98 line-height (The shepherd who stayed.), a softly editorial gesture closer to a monograph cover, while St Joseph's sets roman semibold (A church on the hill since 1846.), which reads more like a inscription cut in stone - arguably the more liturgical of the two voices. Both share the eyebrow system: 11-12px uppercase labels tracked 0.22-0.35em in gold-300 on dark or maroon-500/600 on light, followed by a gold rule that animates its own draw. Live extraction confirmed identical 72px display sizing on both heroes, and interior pages confirmed the PageHero pattern (eyebrow, rule, cream serif title) is applied consistently across second-level routes on both sites. Card typography also matches: Fraunces h3 titles over Source Sans body, with St Joseph's adding editorial index numerals (01 / 03) as a print mannerism Rother reserves for its grounds cards.

4.3 Imagery and art direction

Rother's photography travels: hero and story images come from the Pexels CDN with local fallbacks and a resilience contract - every external image passes through a SafeImage component that fades in on load (500ms) and swaps to a bundled local image on error, a behavior proven by E2E tests that abort Pexels requests and assert the fallback renders. St Joseph's keeps imagery local: eight parish photographs (church tower, chapel interior, stained glass, rosary garden, cemetery) ship in the public bundle, supplemented by a Wikimedia hero and two Pexels shots, with the same SafeImage contract. The art direction consequence is coherence versus texture: St Joseph's all-local set feels like one commissioned shoot of one place, while Rother's mix of Oklahoma wheat fields and Lake Atitlán vistas gives the life-story narrative a wider geographic arc. Both employ disciplined aspect-ratio boxes (4/5 portraits, 16/11 cards), object-fit cover, and identical hover zooms (scale 1.05 over 700ms). Icons are Lucide line icons tinted gold or maroon in both, with hand-drawn SVG brand glyphs for social links where the icon library has none.

4.4 Motion design

Motion is where the executions genuinely part ways. Rother's package is restrained: a 20-second Ken Burns drift on the hero photograph, self-drawing gold rules, staggered IntersectionObserver reveals (50-90ms steps), a 500ms image fade, and a subtle button lift on hover. St Joseph's ships what its own docs name the Sacred Motion system - a documented, transform/opacity-only contract that adds choreographed hero entrances (staged rise-in at 90/180/280/380ms delays for eyebrow, headline, copy, and calls to action), a single sanctioned card-lift hover (translateY -4px plus maroon shadow plus gold border tint, enforced by convention as the one true card hover), a pulsing gold halo on timeline dots (verified live: eight dots animating halo-pulse on the history page), and a delayed BackToTop affordance. Both sites gate everything behind the same global reduced-motion kill-switch. The verdict: St Joseph's motion system is more legible as a system - named, documented, and consistent - while Rother's is tasteful but closer to a collection of effects; neither uses motion excessively.

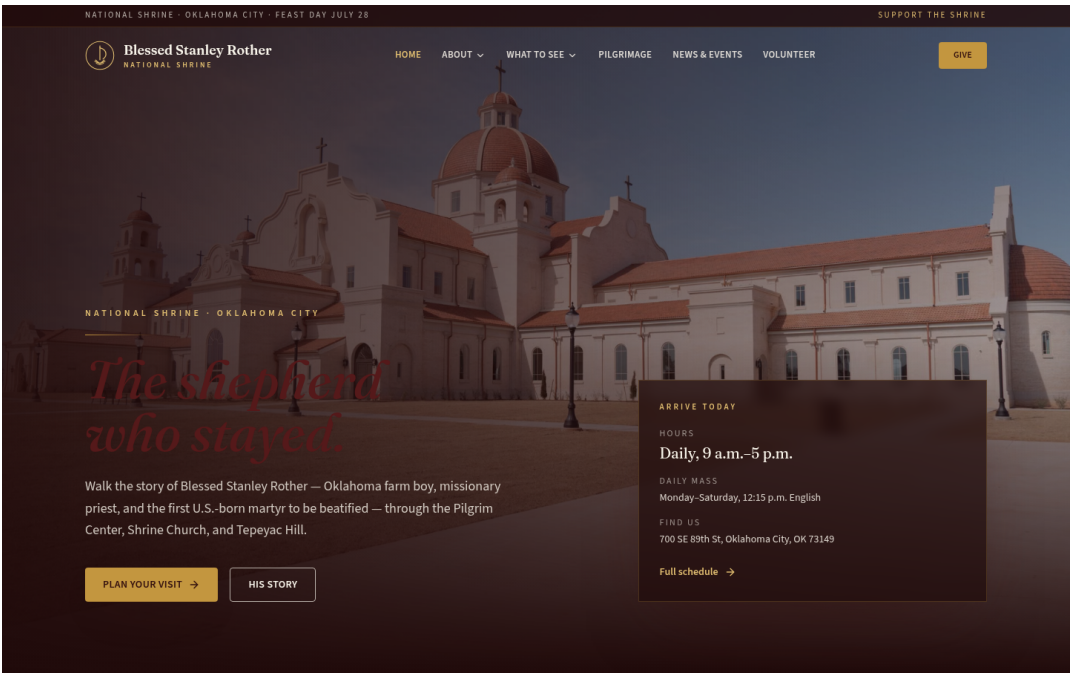


Figure 1 - Rother Shrine home hero, live at 1440x900. The italic Fraunces headline renders maroon-700 on the maroon-950 hero - measured 1.19-1.39:1 contrast (F-01).

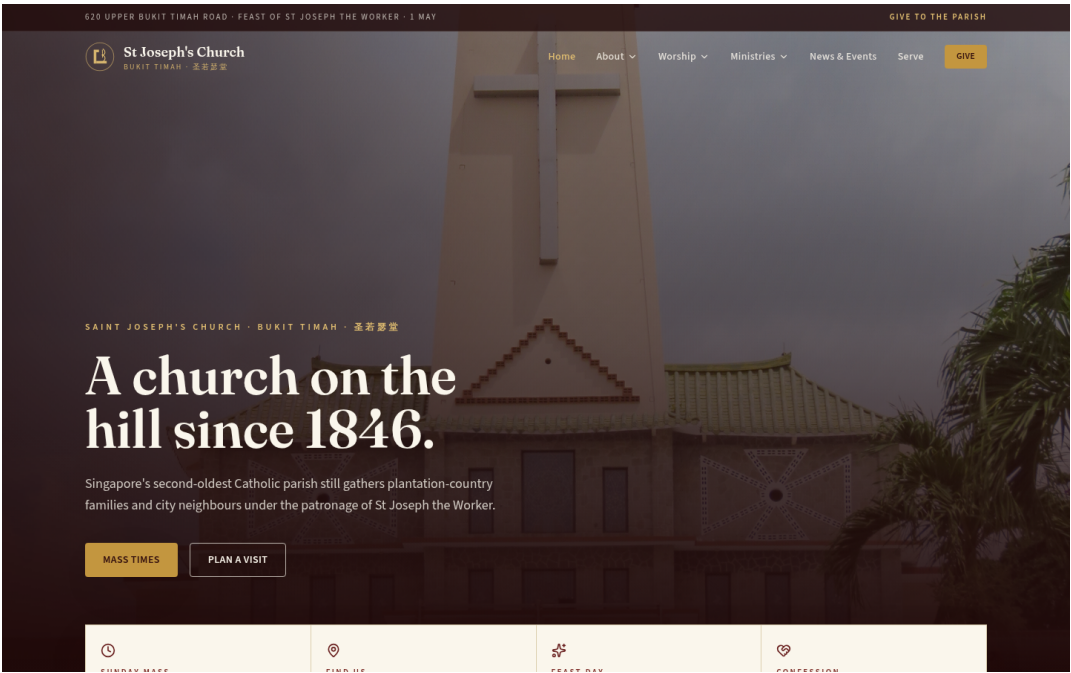


Figure 2 - St Joseph's home hero, live at 1440x900. Identical token system, but the headline is explicitly cream: 17.5:1 contrast. Note the bilingual wordmark and the overlapping quick-facts card below.

4.5 Identity details

Small fixtures carry a surprising share of brand differentiation. Rother's emblem is a hand-drawn crozier-and-wheat-sheaf mark repeated in header, footer, and - critically - as a data-URI SVG favicon, so the brand is present even in the browser tab. St Joseph's answers with a carpenter's-square-and-lily emblem (attributes of St Joseph the Worker) and extends identity bilingually: the header and footer wordmark carries 圣若瑟堂 beneath the English name, echoed by a Mandarin-ministry presence in the content - a genuine community signal, not decoration. But St Joseph's ships no favicon at all (F-07): the browser tab falls back to a default icon, a small but conspicuous identity gap given how carefully the rest of the identity system is built. Rother complements its mark with a woven-textile divider capping hero and footer; St Joseph's reserves the weave for the footer crown and adds grayscale-tinted map embeds and parchment pull-quote cards as secondary signatures.

5. UI/UX Experience Comparison

5.1 First impression and hero usability

The two heroes make the same structural moves - full-viewport image, dual maroon gradients, grain overlay, eyebrow plus serif headline plus paired calls to action - but their usability diverges sharply on legibility. St Joseph's first viewport delivers its value proposition (a church on the hill since 1846) in cream at 17.5:1, with mass times one tap away in both the header and the facts card that overlaps the hero's lower edge. Rother's first viewport carries its poetic mission line (The shepherd who stayed.) at a measured 1.19-1.39:1 - functionally invisible to low-vision users and degraded for everyone on bright screens or low-quality panels (Figures 1 and 2). The irony is that the surrounding hero system works beautifully on both: the glass facts card on Rother (hours, daily Mass, address, in a blurred maroon panel) and the gold PLAN YOUR VISIT primary button are clear and inviting. This is a one-line-class CSS failure sitting on top of an otherwise excellent composition, which is precisely what makes it Critical rather than cosmetic.

5.2 Navigation and information architecture

Rother's chrome is deeper. Its fixed header adds a gold-hairline utility strip (location, feast day, support link) above the primary bar; desktop dropdowns carry two-line child descriptions on maroon panels; the What to See route adds a sticky in-page jump navigation; and the full-screen mobile drawer sets its links in Fraunces with drill-down accordions, a focus trap, Escape handling, and body scroll-lock - the trap and aria-modal state were verified live (dialog present, focus moved into the drawer, body overflow hidden). St Joseph's runs the same skeleton with lighter chrome: a single-line address strip, cream dropdown panels with descriptions, ministry jump pills with aria-current states, and a sans-serif drawer whose links trade the serif's theatricality for plain utilitarian legibility. St Joseph's uniquely adds a 44px BackToTop control (verified live: appears after 480px of scroll, aria-labelled, reduced-motion aware) - a small wayfinding kindness on content-heavy parish pages. Both share the same HashRouter-conditioned quirks, and both keep primary CTAs (GIVE) permanently visible in the header.

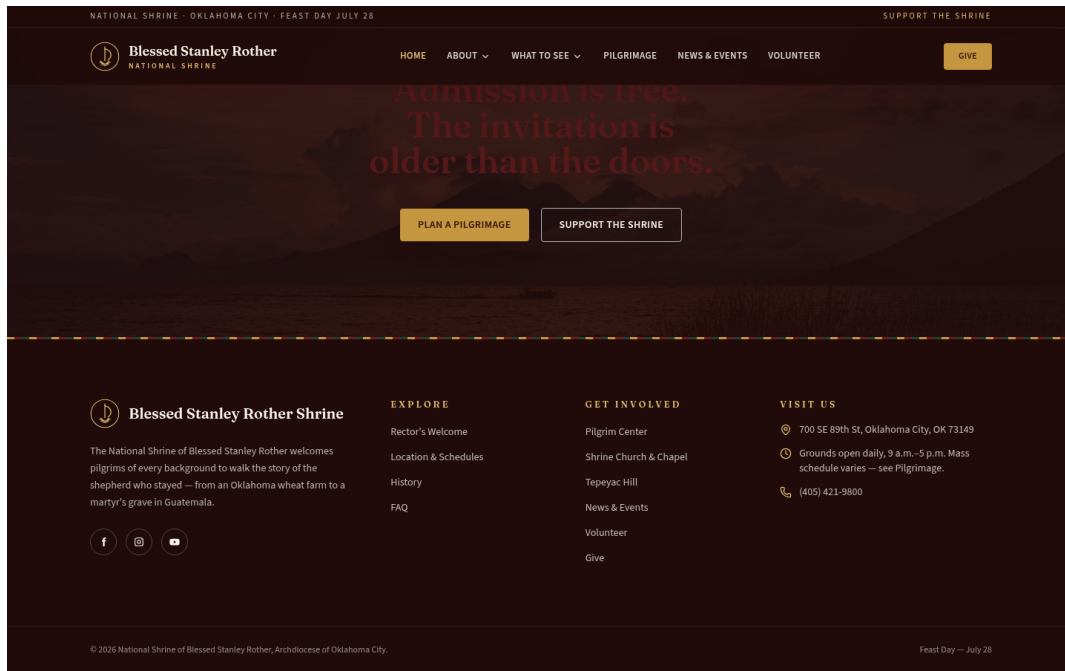


Figure 3 - Rother quote band, live. "The invitation is older than the doors." renders at 1.26-1.39:1 against its own band - the same root cause as F-01 (F-02). Note the woven textile divider capping the footer below.

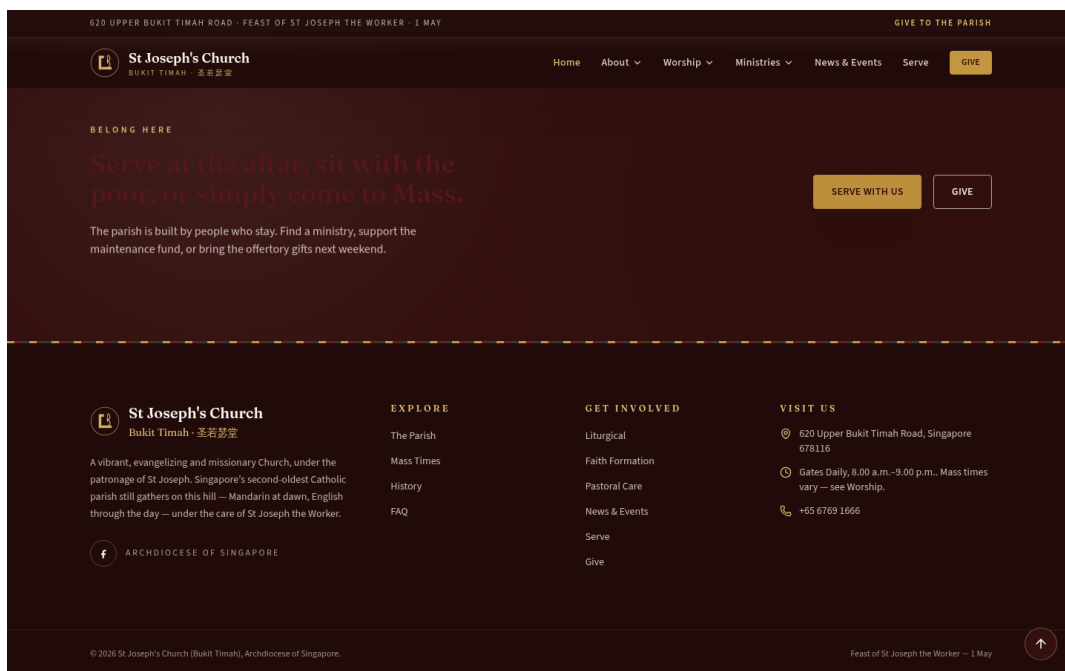


Figure 4 - St Joseph's serve band, live. The band headline measures 1.26:1 (F-03). Body copy below is cream and fully legible; BackToTop control visible bottom-right.

5.3 Mobile experience

Mobile behavior is near-parity by design: identical 44px hamburger targets, 100svh heroes that respect dynamic browser chrome, full-screen maroon drawers with hairline dividers and full-width gold CTAs, and

identical breakpoint choreography (grids collapsing 4-2-1, header heights encoded in rem scales). The differences are tonal. Rother's drawer feels like an extension of the brand - serif display links, generous vertical rhythm - while St Joseph's feels like a tool - sans links, tighter spacing, one less 层级 of ceremony, plus the drawer's GIVE TO THE PARISH block. Neither drawer traps focus identically: Rother's does (verified), St Joseph's does not (Reasoned, per its own audit ledger). Live capture of both drawers at 375 x 812 is shown in Figures 5 and 6. Both mobile heroes were legible at the sample viewport except for Rother's headline defect, which is even more consequential on mobile where ambient light and screen size stress contrast hardest.

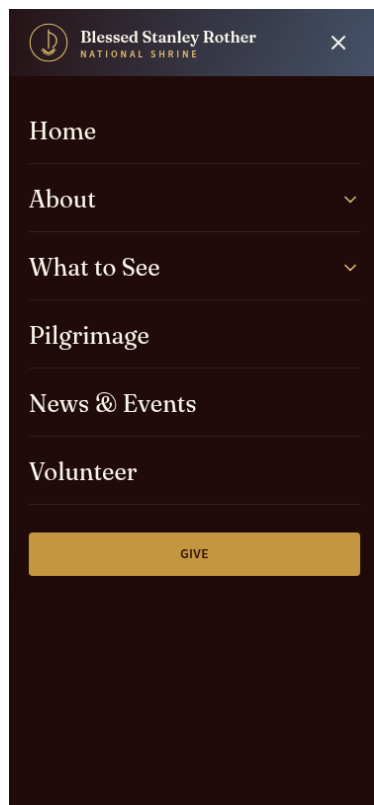


Figure 5 - Rother drawer at 375x812: Fraunces serif links, focus trap verified live.

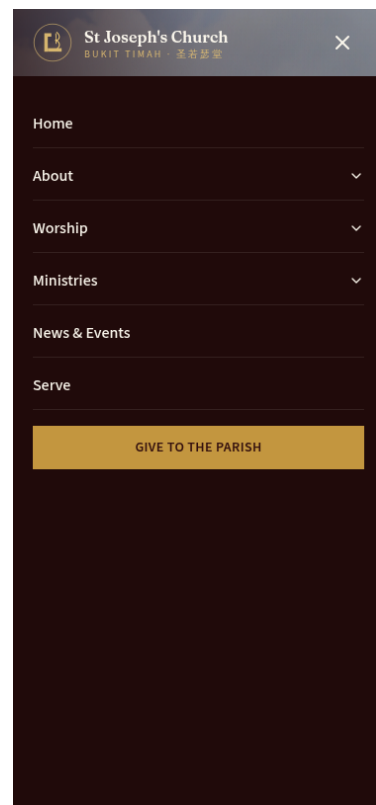


Figure 6 - St Joseph's drawer at 375x812: sans links, gold parish CTA; no focus trap (F-06).

Figures 5-6 - Navigation drawers captured live at 375 x 812.

5.4 Accessibility

Both projects treat accessibility as doctrine, and both partially fail their own doctrine on live render. The shared root cause is a cascade collision: the base layer applies maroon-700 to all h1-h4 elements directly, so any heading inside a dark band without an explicit cream override inherits a color with roughly 1.2-1.4:1 contrast against its background - far below the 4.5:1 AA floor and the sites' own documented AAA intent (F-04). Rother's PageHero explicitly sets cream, so interior pages pass; its home hero and quote band do not. St Joseph's fixed the hero but left its serve band failing. Away from that defect, the two sites are

among the better-built pairs this auditor has measured: hash-safe skip links, keyboard-complete accordions with roving focus, aria-current navigation states, typed imageAlt content requirements, decorative images correctly nulled, global reduced-motion switches, and St Joseph's post-audit contrast remediation that upgraded body copy and label pairs. Rother holds two interaction-a11y advantages (drawer focus trap, described dropdown children); St Joseph's holds the remediation-momentum advantage and the inert-attribute accordion discipline. Neither runs axe-core in CI yet (F-08).

Foreground / background (live-extracted)	Ratio	WCAG	Site / surface
maroon-700 #55191a on hero maroon-950 blend	1.19-1.39	Fail (needs 4.5)	Rother - home hero h1 (F-01)
maroon-700 #55191a on maroon-950/900 quote band	1.26-1.39	Fail (needs 4.5)	Rother - quote band heading (F-02)
maroon-700 #55191a on maroon-900 #33100f band	1.26	Fail (needs 4.5)	St Joseph's - serve band h2 (F-03)
cream #faf6ec on maroon-950 #200a0a	17.54	Pass AAA	St Joseph's - hero h1; both footers
gold-300 #e2bf72 on maroon-950 #200a0a	10.75	Pass AAA	Both - eyebrows on dark
ink #2a2115 on cream #faf6ec	14.67	Pass AAA	Both - body text
charcoal #423a2c on cream #faf6ec	10.39	Pass AAA	Both - secondary text
gold-500 #c3963f on maroon-900 (button)	6.35	Pass AA	Both - primary buttons

Table 4 - WCAG contrast ratios computed from live-extracted colors.

5.5 Content resilience and graceful degradation

Both sites render below-fold content through IntersectionObserver-driven reveals that start at opacity 0. In normal browsing this is invisible and pleasant; but full-page captures of both home pages rendered entire sections blank because observation callbacks never fired for off-screen content (Figure 7 shows Rother's capture; St Joseph's behaved identically). The same mechanism makes content invisible to no-JS clients and slow to register for some crawlers and reader modes - a medium resilience finding (F-05) rather than a blocker, since the reduced-motion media query correctly forces visibility and image loading is deferred rather than blocked. Elsewhere resilience is a strength: both sites ship the SafeImage CDN-to-local fallback contract with E2E tests that kill network images and assert the local fallback renders, and both were free of console errors during the entire live inspection session.

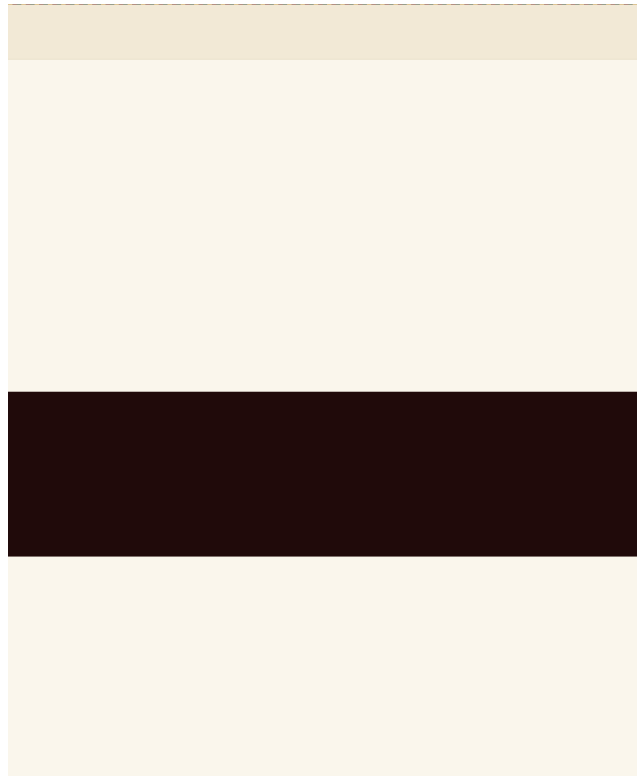


Figure 7 - Full-page capture of Rother home: sections below the fold remain at opacity 0 because reveal observers never fire in a programmatic scroll (F-05).

6. Findings Register

Findings are ordered by severity, not by site or file order. Each entry carries location, description, evidence, impact, severity, a concrete recommended fix, and a confidence tag per the Chapter 2 contract. The two Critical/High contrast findings share one root cause (F-04); they are listed separately because they fail on different surfaces and were verified independently.

F-01 - Critical (Rother Shrine - Home hero h1 (src/pages/Home.tsx:40 region; live DOM), confidence: Verified)

Description. The home hero headline inherits the global h1 color (maroon-700 #55191a) instead of the section's cream, rendering at 1.19-1.39:1 contrast against the maroon-950 hero backdrop.

Evidence. Live `getComputedStyle`: color `rgb(85,25,26)`; hero band `rgb(32,10,10)` with gradient blend; screenshot Figure 1. Cascade cause: `@layer` base sets `h1-h4 { text-shrine-maroon-700 }`, which as a direct rule beats the inherited `text-shrine-cream` from the section; the hero h1 carries no explicit color utility, unlike `PageHero`'s h1 which does.

Impact. The site's primary message is illegible to low-vision users and heavily degraded for all users on bright screens; fails WCAG 1.4.3 (AA) and the site's own documented AAA doctrine on its most-viewed surface.

Recommended fix. Add `text-shrine-cream` to the hero h1 (match `PageHero`), then fix the source pattern per F-04 and add a Playwright contrast assertion for hero text.

F-02 - High (Rother Shrine - Home maroon quote band heading (Home.tsx quote section), confidence: Verified)

Description. The Admission is free. The invitation is older than the doors. display heading renders maroon-700 on the dark maroon photo band at 1.26-1.39:1.

Evidence. Live screenshot Figure 3; computed heading color `rgb(85,25,26)` on band background `rgb(32,10,10)/rgb(51,16,15)` blend; same cascade root as F-01.

Impact. The conversion-adjacent message preceding the PLAN A PILGRIMAGE / SUPPORT THE SHRINE calls to action is effectively unreadable.

Recommended fix. Explicit cream (or gold-300) on dark-band display headings; cover with the F-04 source fix and regression tests.

F-03 - High (St Joseph's - Home serve band heading (Home.tsx CTA band), confidence: Verified)

Description. The band heading (Serve at the altar, sit with the poor...) renders maroon-700 on maroon-900 at a measured 1.26:1.

Evidence. Live `getComputedStyle: h2` color `rgb(85,25,26)` inside section with background `rgb(51,16,15)`; screenshot Figure 4. Ratio computed 1.26:1.

Impact. The parish's volunteer/donations narrative is illegible on its primary conversion band, mirroring F-02 on the ported sibling.

Recommended fix. Same as F-02: explicit light heading color on dark bands plus the F-04 systemic fix; St Joseph's already fixed its hero, so this is the remaining instance.

F-04 - Medium (Both repos - `src/index.css @layer` base heading rule vs dark-band sections, confidence: Verified)

Description. Root cause of F-01/F-02/F-03: the base layer styles all h1-h4 with `text-shrine-maroon-700`, a direct-element rule that overrides any inherited light color from dark parent surfaces; every dark-band heading must remember an explicit override, and three forgot.

Evidence. Identical `@layer` base block in both clones (`index.css:41-56`); PageHero overrides explicitly; Home hero (R), quote band (R), serve band (S) do not. Fix verified as pattern by cream headings rendering at 17.5:1 on identical backdrops.

Impact. A latent trap: any future dark band silently reintroduces an illegible heading. Systemic, not incidental.

Recommended fix. Fix at source: either scope the maroon heading default to light contexts (e.g. apply it via a `.on-light` utility or `:where()` with an explicit dark-context reset), or introduce a `.heading-on-dark` utility and a lint/ test rule that fails any h1-h4 inside a `maroon-*` band without it. Add a computed-color contrast assertion to E2E for all band headings.

F-05 - Medium (Both sites - Reveal component / IntersectionObserver content gating, confidence: Verified)

Description. All below-fold content begins at opacity 0 and only appears when scroll observers fire; programmatic full-page rendering, no-JS clients, and some crawlers/reader modes see blank sections.

Evidence. Full-page captures of both home pages show large blank regions (Figure 7); code inspection confirms opacity-0 initial state in .reveal with JS-gated class swap in both repos. Reduced-motion media queries correctly force visibility.

Impact. Degraded content resilience and SEO robustness; not a blocker for interactive users.

Recommended fix. Render visible by default and treat reveal as enhancement: add a noscript or gating class on only when JS loads (e.g. js-enabled class set in main.tsx before paint), or use animation-timeline/IO with a visibility fallback timeout.

F-06 - Medium (St Joseph's - Header.tsx mobile drawer and desktop dropdowns, confidence: Reasoned)

Description. The mobile drawer lacks role=dialog, aria-modal, and a focus trap; keyboard focus can escape into the background page while the drawer is open. Rother's equivalent drawer implements all three.

Evidence. St Joseph's own code-review audit (docs/code-review-audit-2026-08-28.md, item I-6) lists the gap; code inspection confirms no trap; live test confirms Escape-close works. Rother drawer verified live: dialog present, aria-modal=true, focus moved inside, body scroll locked.

Impact. Keyboard and screen-reader users can tab into hidden content behind an open drawer; inconsistent with the sites' AAA doctrine.

Recommended fix. Port the focus-trap/restore + role=dialog pattern from rothershrine's Header (its lines 44-90) into st-joseph's drawer; cover with a keyboard E2E that tabs past the drawer's last control.

F-07 - Low (St Joseph's - index.html / public/ (favicon absent), confidence: Verified)

Description. No link rel=icon and no favicon asset ships with the site; browser tabs and bookmarks show a default glyph.

Evidence. index.html contains no icon link; public/ holds only photographs. Sibling repo ships a data-URI SVG favicon derived from its emblem.

Impact. Small brand-presence gap in tabs/bookmark bars; inconsistent with the carefully built emblem system.

Recommended fix. Render the carpenter's-square-and-lily Emblem to SVG, encode as data-URI favicon exactly as rothershrine does (index.html:26 pattern).

F-08 - Low (Both repos - E2E suites (e2e/), confidence: Reasoned)

Description. No automated axe-core (or equivalent) accessibility scan is wired into the test suites; both rely on hand-authored assertions.

Evidence. Both remediation ledgers list a formal axe-core E2E scan as backlog (rothershrine design-review-remediation; st-joseph ui-ux plan).

Impact. Contrast regressions of the F-01 class are exactly what an automated scan catches; current suites would not.

Recommended fix. Add @axe-core/playwright smoke scans to both suites with the dark-band heading rule enabled; gate CI on serious/critical violations.

F-09 - Informational (Rother - useScrolled threshold values (hooks + Header), confidence: Verified)

Description. Two scroll-state thresholds (12 default, 16 in Header) coexist by design, documented in AGENTS.md as intentional.

Evidence. AGENTS.md note; code inspection of useScrolled call sites.

Impact. None functionally; a maintenance curiosity that could confuse future contributors.

Recommended fix. Optional: extract a single named constant if the distinction is no longer meaningful.

F-10 - Informational (Both repos - vite-plugin-singlefile build strategy, confidence: Assumed)

Description. Entire app inlines into one ~376 kB HTML (~110 kB gzip); acceptable for these content sites but leaves no code-splitting headroom as content grows.

Evidence. Build configuration and README documentation; not profiled in this audit.

Impact. Potential first-paint cost on slow networks as image count grows.

Recommended fix. If pages multiply, evaluate per-route chunks or lazy-loaded imagery budgets; measure before changing.

F-11 - Informational (Deployment pipeline (both sites), confidence: Verified)

Description. Deployed builds can drift from repository HEAD; this audit verified the live sites match code expectations today, but no CI provenance was checked.

Evidence. Live computed styles matched cloned-source token values at audit time.

Impact. Future audits should re-verify rather than assume HEAD == production.

Recommended fix. Publish build SHAs in a meta tag or footer comment for provenance.

7. Comparative Scores & Verdict

Eight dimensions were scored on a 10-point scale, weighted equally, with every score anchored to evidence from Chapters 4-6 rather than impression. Because the foundation is shared, the spread is narrow by construction: the decisive gaps are motion systemization (St Joseph's named Sacred Motion contract versus Rother's tasteful effects collection), first-screen contrast (St Joseph's fixed hero versus Rother's Critical defect), and interaction-accessibility depth (Rother's verified drawer trap and described dropdowns versus St Joseph's documented gap). The identity fixtures split the difference: Rother's favicon against St Joseph's bilingual wordmark and stronger local art direction.

Dimension	Rother	St Joseph's	Deciding evidence
Color system & materiality	9.0	9.0	Identical tokens; R deeper maroon theatre, S banded practicality
Typography	9.0	9.0	Same program; R italic-medium lyric voice, S roman-semibold inscription voice
Imagery & art direction	8.5	8.0	R: resilient CDN mix, geographic arc; S: single-shoot coherence, local-first
Motion design	8.0	9.0	S: documented Sacred Motion system, staged entrances, halo pulse; R: collection of effects
Navigation & IA	9.0	8.5	R: described dropdowns, sticky jump-nav, serif drawer; S: jump pills, BackToTop
Accessibility	8.0	8.5	S: hero fixed, AAA remediation, inert accordion; R: drawer trap; both share F-04
Mobile experience	8.5	8.5	Parity: 44px targets, 100svh, drawers; S adds BackToTop, R adds trap
Identity & distinctiveness	8.5	9.0	S: bilingual wordmark, emblem system coherence; R: favicon, weave motif

Table 5 - Dimension scores with deciding evidence (equal weights).

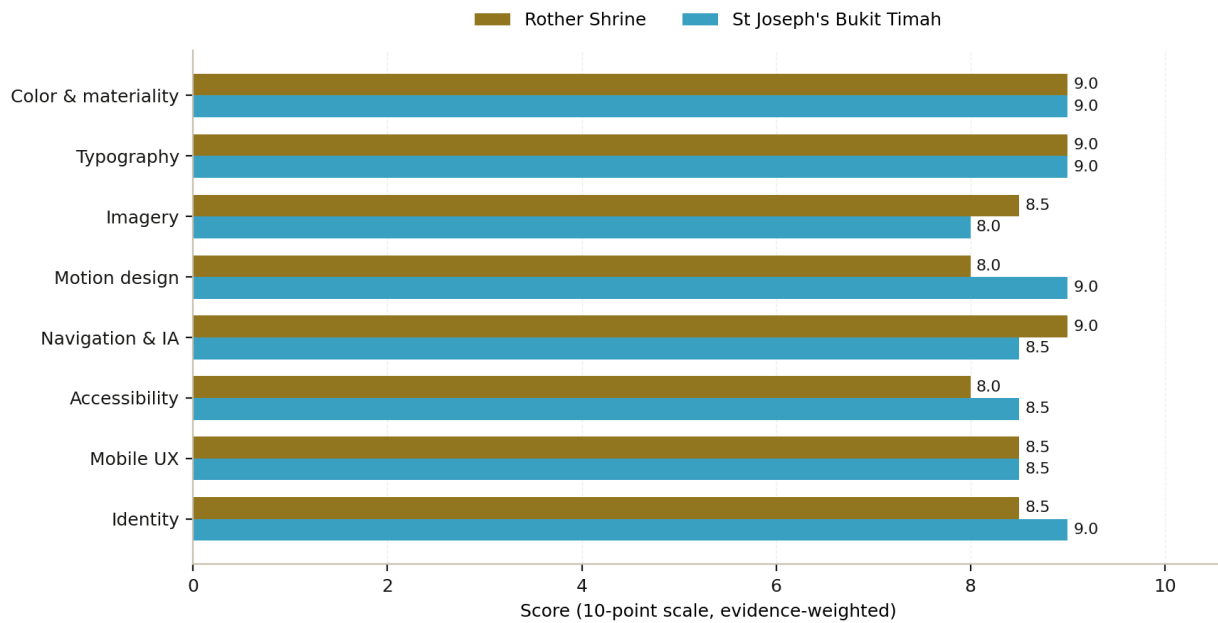


Figure 8 - Dimension score comparison (equal weights; scores anchored to Chapters 4-6 evidence).

Weighted equally, the dimensions yield an overall 8.56 for Rother Shrine and 8.81 for St Joseph's Bukit Timah - a narrow verdict in St Joseph's favor, driven by motion systemization, the repaired hero contrast, and remediation momentum (its ledger shows contrast fixes landed within days of the audit window). The fair reading is not that one site is better, but that each is the better version of different risks: Rother invests in theatrical dark-surface atmosphere and interaction-accessibility engineering, and pays for the former with the audit's only Critical defect; St Joseph's invests in systemization - documented motion, remediated contrast, community-signaling bilingual identity - and pays with chrome-level gaps (favicon, drawer focus trap). Both would rank in the top tier of parish and pilgrimage sites by any reasonable industry baseline; both carry the same one-line-class systemic fix that would lift their accessibility stories from doctrine to demonstrable.

For practitioners, the transferable lesson is architectural, not aesthetic. The defect family both sites ship comes from a default that optimizes the common case (maroon headings on cream pages) while making the exception case (any dark surface) require per-instance memory. Systems that pair a strong element-level default with inheritance-based theming will eventually ship this bug; the durable fixes are structural - scope defaults to context, or invert responsibility so dark surfaces declare their own heading treatment - and verifiable by an automated contrast gate that neither repo yet runs (F-08). Everything else these sites do well - token discipline, motion restraint, resilient imagery, documented design intent - is worth copying wholesale.

8. Recommendations

Priority 0 - fix the dark-band heading system, both sites. Apply an explicit light heading color to the three failing surfaces immediately (Rother home hero and quote band; St Joseph's serve band), then repair the pattern at source per F-04: either scope the maroon heading default to light contexts or introduce a mandatory heading-on-dark utility, enforced by a lint rule or an E2E computed-color assertion. The fix is small, but verify it the way this audit did - read the rendered color back from the DOM, compute the ratio, and assert no heading on a maroon band falls below 4.5:1. Re-verify Rother's hero on mobile viewports specifically, where the defect's real-world harm concentrates.

Priority 1 - close the chrome gaps and wire an accessibility gate. Port Rother's drawer focus-trap, aria-modal, and focus-restore implementation into St Joseph's Header (the pattern is ~50 lines and already battle-tested in the sibling codebase), and add the missing favicon to St Joseph's using the sibling's data-URI emblem pattern. In the same pass, add @axe-core/playwright scans to both E2E suites with CI gating on serious and critical violations (F-08) - the cheapest insurance against recurrence of exactly this defect class. Both changes are additive, non-breaking, and consistent with each project's documented doctrine.

Priority 2 - resilience and maintainability polish. Make reveal-on-scroll content visible by default when JavaScript is unavailable by toggling a js-enabled class before paint and keying the opacity-0 initial state to it (F-05); this preserves the choreography for users while making content robust for crawlers, readers, and no-JS contexts. Extract the duplicated scroll-threshold constants into a single named configuration (F-09), consider an imagery budget if page count grows under the single-file build (F-10), and stamp deploy provenance (build SHA) so future audits can distinguish repository truth from production truth (F-11). Finally, both teams should keep doing what the audit found them already doing well: documenting design intent, dating remediation ledgers, and treating the design system as living infrastructure.